

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 663

By Oliver

A RESOLUTION to honor and congratulate Meharry Medical College upon the celebration of its 150th anniversary.

WHEREAS, it is most appropriate that the members of this General Assembly should honor and congratulate those venerable institutions of higher learning in the State of Tennessee whose enduring achievements have garnered universal acclaim; and

WHEREAS, one such distinguished institution is Meharry Medical College, which in 2026 marks the 150th anniversary of its founding in Nashville, a sesquicentennial milestone that commemorates a remarkable legacy of service, scholarship, and leadership; and

WHEREAS, Meharry Medical College was established in 1876 as the Medical Department of Central Tennessee College, opening its doors in the basement of a local church with eleven students and two faculty instructors and guided by the vision of co-founders Dr. George W. Hubbard and Dr. William J. Snead; and

WHEREAS, the institution became the first medical school in the South for African Americans and the first medical school in the South, historically Black or otherwise, to offer four-year medical training; and

WHEREAS, the college's origins are rooted in an inspiring story of compassion: a young Ohioan named Samuel Meharry, moved by an act of kindness from a freed couple early in his life, went on to return their random act of kindness by pledging the cash and property necessary to found Meharry Medical College; and

WHEREAS, over the course of its first five decades, Meharry Medical College expanded its academic programs with the founding of the School of Dentistry in 1886 and the School of Pharmacy in 1889 and graduating pioneering physicians and leaders whose service reached far beyond Tennessee; and

WHEREAS, among these trailblazers was Dr. Georgia Esther Lee Patton Washington, who in 1893, became the first Black woman to graduate from Meharry and the first Black woman licensed to practice medicine and surgery in the State of Tennessee; she was also the first Meharry graduate to serve in Africa, returning in 1895 to practice in Memphis; and

WHEREAS, Meharry Medical College achieved autonomy in 1915 with its separate charter, further advancing its mission, broadening its reach, and establishing itself as an independent, enduring academic health sciences center; and

WHEREAS, since 1876, Meharry Medical College has been a pioneer in training Black physicians, dentists, scientists, and healthcare leaders dedicated to advancing health access and equity; from breaking barriers in medical education to leading public health innovation, Meharry's legacy is rooted in service to communities often left behind; and

WHEREAS, Meharry Medical College is today home to five major schools: School of Applied Computational Sciences, School of Dentistry, School of Global Health, School of Graduate Studies, and School of Medicine, each providing an excellent education that prepares leaders in medicine, dentistry, global health, computational sciences, and biomedical science who are dedicated to the elimination of health disparities; and

WHEREAS, Meharry Medical College continues to advance its mission under the astute leadership of its twelfth president and chief executive officer, James E.K. Hildreth, Sr., Ph.D., M.D., a nationally renowned leader whose commitment to health equity, research innovation, and educational excellence has strengthened Meharry's role as a cornerstone of medical education and community service; and

WHEREAS, in celebration of this sesquicentennial, Meharry has launched a yearlong series of commemorations and initiatives, including Campaign 150, an ambitious strategy to strengthen institutional excellence, expand community care, foster research and innovation, and

prepare future generations of health professionals to meet the complex demands of tomorrow's health challenges; and

WHEREAS, on this momentous occasion of 150 years of transformative leadership and service, it is appropriate that we honor this historic institution for its indelible contributions to education, health care, and the citizens of this State; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor and congratulate Meharry Medical College on the celebration of its 150th anniversary, extending our best wishes for continued leadership, excellence, and service in the years to come.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.